Copyright Statement

The Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College has made a reasonable effort to secure permission from the interviewees to make these materials available to the public. Use of these materials by other parties is subject to the fair use doctrine in United States copyright law (Title 17, Chapter 1, Section 107) which allows use for commentary, criticism, news reporting, research, teaching or scholarship without requiring permission from the rights holder.

Any use that does not fall within fair use must be cleared with the rights holder. For assistance in contacting the rights holder please contact the Fillius Jazz Archive, Hamilton College, 198 College Hill Road, Clinton, NY 13323 (315) 859-4071.

Ran Blake

Ran Blake has distinguished himself as a composer, educator, and performer, with more than thirty recordings to his credit. He is the author of the book The Primacy of the Ear*, and served as the Chair of the New England Conservatory Contemporary Improvisation Department from 1972 until 2005.*

Ran was interviewed via Zoom on July 16, 2021 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: I'm very pleased to welcome Ran Blake today to join us for the Fillius Jazz Archive. Mr. Blake, it's a pleasure and I wish I was sitting next to you, but the Zoom will suffice for today.

RB: Maybe there'll be another time.

MR: Maybe so.

RB: And I've been a listener to your wonderful interviews, and feel really honored to be here.

MR: Thank you. I'd like to see if I can get inside your mind today.

RB: Good luck.

MR: And by that I mean I'd like to start with on your website there's a recording of "Time Remembered" and —

RB: Yes, Bill Evans.

MR: Yeah. It's about 7-1/2 minutes and I have a couple of questions about it. As you play it do you know where you're going from one moment to the next?

RB: I do a lot of dress rehearsals away from the piano, and I often conceive the beginning, in fact I'm rusty at this piece now, I haven't heard my interpretation, but I think I usually have my ear to guide me and sometimes I think of plot summaries and I'm recalling Bill Evans with Perry and his brother in the Berkshires, the Lenox School of Jazz, where I studied with Bill and Oscar. So I think up, I think I do but sometimes I'm not sure I'm the one to answer. Yes I think, but many free players, I'm very pleased you invited me, I'm not sure I'm really the orthodox jazz that you love, really, but I think in dark channels —

MR: You will be adding a nice element to our collection. And I'm wondering as you play a piece like that, or your own compositions, and you're sort of in the middle of it, do you ever surprise yourself by where your hands go and the sounds that are created?

RB: Yes I do. I'm only semi-conscious at the time because when I play "Laura" I think of Gene Tierney and Clifton Webb and the movies, so there are a lot of different plot things when I do the Theodorakis [inaudible] I think of the coup d'état in Greece in 1967, so their imageries, and they almost overpower me. And sometimes that's why I like to play alone or a duo, because the plots and the characters come right to me. It's very hard to

subtly be present and aware. I do hear some things back but there are so many CDs I haven't heard of other people and DVDs of film noir. But I think I am surprised. I like to modulate. I don't plan that but my hands seem to like that.

MR: It must be an abrupt feeling for you to get interrupted and sort of yanked out of that mind connection to the physical that it seems like you have going.

RB: Yeah. I'm out of it when people speak to me after a concert, but even, I really, I know enough to bow when I come out on stage and I know I'm in part playing for an audience and then I feel self-conscious the first number, but then the lights are down, I usually play in the dark, and I just feel like a movie is being screened in front of me.

MR: Are you able to turn the music off in your head during the day if you're not near the piano or is there always something going on musically for you?

RB: There's a lot going on but sometimes I force myself to turn it off because I want my ears to have a rest. I don't want the phone, even a film noir film. I just get a mystery thriller and sometimes I succeed in turning the sound off but not always.

MR: Here's a quote from you: "If anything musicians have too many gigs and don't put in enough listening time. They mostly want to hear themselves regardless of how it sounds. Many don't truly hear themselves, their friends or the past to know what the future should sound like."

RB: Are you going to have me assassinated? I can think of — suddenly — well there's a window right here they could come in. That's very arrogant of me implying that of course I have all the answers and I listen — I didn't mean to — is that from my book?

MR: It's on your website I believe and I don't find it arrogant. I think that there's some truth to it, sometimes just very practical things — musicians are so busy trying to prepare or negotiate the next gig —

RB: Yeah, that's important.

MR: Yeah. That they may not have time to sit and really listen. And then of course there's musicians who sort of their ego can be a little out of control and they're mostly listening to themselves instead of what's going on around them.

RB: Well we all have a little bit of ego so maybe I'm guilty of that, but there's so many people I treasure in music and in film.

MR: I wonder if you're familiar with Karl Berger's approach to music?

RB: I know he's taught at Woodstock, I know we played a duet once in Philadelphia in the mid-60s I think, after Trane made his trip to heaven, but I really don't — could you fill me in a little more about Karl?

MR: I have a quote from him, and you know he — it would be a big generalization to say that he does free jazz, but he does lead workshops in free jazz, I don't think he objects that we use that term, but there's a little anecdote I read and it connects to something that you

talked about in a recent interview with Ornette Coleman, and Ornette sitting in with the Herb Pomeroy Orchestra and you had this wonderful analogy, I believe it was yours, that it was like mixing water from the bayou with water from the North Pole.

RB: I like the water from the bayou, I swim. I believe I said that, that was at the Music in the Berkshires. And I love Herb. I know Fred Harris from MIT is doing a biography, and I love his appreciation of Duke, the sound of the orchestra. But when you think that Phil Woods is going to play and suddenly pops out Ornette, it was explosive. John Lewis went like that, Martin Williams, a wonderful critic, really practically flipped, and of course Gunther was sitting there — this was an afternoon rehearsal but Gunther knew what to expect. He always does. But I've never forgotten that. I have so many memories of Lenox. One time Gerry Mulligan criticizing John Lewis in front of a whole audience about not being up to date with the harmonies. Boy I crossed Mulligan off my list after that. But so many memories of that wonderful school.

MR: Well what brought me to this was Karl Berger was led to this statement. He had heard Eric Dolphy in '64 and we were talking about freedom and free jazz. And he said, "More freedom is not about less precision, it's about more precision. The more precise you get the more free you are." He says, "I'm creating my own rules and they're much more stringent." I wonder if you could comment on that, because it's always fascinated me, we think about free jazz as the ultimate no constraints, and he's saying the opposite.

RB: Well some free jazz is very free and I look for some history. I've never heard that comment. I would like to read further about Karl. I'm not sure how to — he's not just talking about free jazz being precise, he's really mentioning his own vocabulary and what he sees when he's performing with people maybe who agree with him, and having not followed his career, I do like to follow careers but I haven't had the chance with Karl. So I think I can't really judge this without hearing some of his music.

MR: Well I'll send you a little transcript of what he had to say. It's quite interesting.

RB: Yeah.

MR: So these days, or throughout your career, can you describe to me where your inspiration to compose can come from?

RB: They come from a sense of life, they come from the street, they come from film noir and to be more precise I think of Thelonious all the time, Abbey Lincoln, Billie Holiday, Al Green, Ray Charles, you can guess what my favorite instrument is. Piano is my third favorite. And I think of Bartok and Olivier Messiaen "Quartet for All Time," and the palette of Debussy, and that I might switch to Humphrey Bogart, Ethel Barrymore, and Dorothy Dandridge. So these memories come right back to me.

MR: Would you say your music, I'm not sure how to put this, but a number of composers have written what we call programmatic music. They're trying to capture an event, a setting. Is

your music programmatic in a sense that you were inspired by something and you are trying to capture it in your music? In your piano music?

RB: I think so but sometimes I mean Beethoven was very deliberate on the Pastoral Symphony. I know there've been many pieces that describe a character. I think instead of trying to capture it though, it captures me.

MR: And what do you expect or hope that your listener derives from the music?

RB: I hope some enjoyment, some engaging attention. I believe there is sort of a under — there are things that are not terribly noticeable. I may pick a quote that's, I mean everybody could talk about freedom in France and do the National Anthem but I think there's a subtext to my music, and as long as I don't bore the audience, the listener, I'm somewhat happy.

MR: I'm glad you said that because one of the little things I had jotted down was your awareness of who's listening while you're playing.

RB: Yeah.

MR: And do you sense, do you get a sense of the audience when you're on stage? I'm not sure, do you feel a vibe or something, and may it direct the way you play?

RB: It could. Sometimes I pre-think this. I played in a West Switzerland in the French area and here I reviewed a lot of Edith Piaf repertoire but I forgot about age. These were young people. They were bored stiff. I had a small handful, they seemed to disappear at intermission. I think somebody bought me a drink, maybe out of pity. But so I try, but of course I have been, I did more of my panel a day or two afterwards when I play in Tours, France for an audience that I've worked with for three — for days. I sometimes I really get more of an idea of what people are like. But no, I cannot walk out in Jordan Hall or Chateau Les in Paris and suddenly say, oh these are — oh that's the man that loves cheese from Bordeaux, or that's Claude Chabrol from Tremolat. No is it Spike Lee? No it's Chabrol. So I sometimes fail miserably.

MR: Okay. Well that's a hard thing, and I think it's even harder in a concert setting than it might be in a club. Sometimes you can catch a vibe in a club.

RB: Yes.

MR: There's something to play to.

RB: And I've done not so much club work. I had a wonderful time at a club in Madrid, the Whiskey Jazz Club, which closed about fifteen, twenty years ago. And there some of the musicians were okay, but somehow some sculptures or painters liked my music and it was so reassuring in getting to know the place, the lighting I wanted, etcetera, etcetera. But I feel like many people who really need the gigs for survival sometimes still unprepared.

MR: I saw another interesting quote from you describing the content of *The Primacy of the Ear*. I'm not sure you wrote this, but the person who wrote the review said one thing that you addressed was how to listen to your musical heroes without being consumed by them. And it made me think of Charlie Parker and everybody who came after him. So how do you not become consumed by your musical heroes?

RB: Well first, speaking for myself, I don't know if I am or not. I know that a colleague of mine who runs the Third Stream Contemporary Improvisation Department, I've studied Yiddish music with him, Klezmer, and he said, "By all means bring in your dark clouds and your sensibility but try to occasionally at the beginning get to the style and let's hear more melody." And I've tried to do that, sometimes succeeded, often not. I don't think I wrote that but I think probably somebody quoted it. And who will decide whether the style and the hero worship is fully integrated in the person who's playing it with her and his own personality and when it is more of a student admiration where, and I think it's very good for people at the beginning of a style to try to be very respectful of the model. And I am when I go — I wish I could play bebop but I struggle, but when I did "Yardbird Suite" that was a few years ago with Anthony, well I didn't have to worry about being a Charlie Parker, how I love him, but his speed, his assurance — that's a —

MR: Which Anthony was that?

RB: Braxton.

MR: Oh Anthony Braxton. Oh my.

RB: We did it in an album called "One Night in Vienna."

MR: Well that would have — I'd like to hear that.

RB: Well be my guest. I think a Charlie Parker purist would say that maybe I'm trying to dig in but that it's a little bit counterfeit. But I just didn't want to only stay with Billie Holiday ballads and the beautiful longing and expressions of Mahalia Jackson. I have to once in a while dig myself out of a hole. But I do love models, they're very very important.

MR: Yes. Do you think it's harder for young musicians to find something new to present, to find a style that hasn't already been done. We've had a hundred years or so of jazz and it's been through so many iterations. Like what's a young player supposed to do now to stand out from the crowd?

RB: Well they certainly don't go back to "Muggles" by Louis Armstrong. They love Amy Winehouse, maybe somebody — Abbey Lincoln can capture an audience but a lot of the people from the past, I mean Charlie Parker as few peers in jazz but so many of the people coming in right now are not really aware. They don't seem to have spent time with Robin Kelley's beautiful book on Thelonious. When I mention a lady called Nica Koenigswarter Rothschild, who I was a waiter in New York and I waited a special table

on her. I learned never to put ice in her glass. I don't know if they know what I'm talking about. But there are so many things they know that I don't. I know Oliva, who's, Olive is working with Biden to get people vaccinations. So I try to keep up with trends but —

MR: That's true, young people today, they are so —

RB: They want youth.

MR: I could use a bit of that. And the way they learn is quite different. They can pick whatever they want to hear off the internet and very different from the way we grew up.

RB: And they want the written music too.

MR: They want to read?

RB: They really prefer to read music, to develop the ear. Now I have some written music here too because some notes I can't hear if it goes fast, but there was my courses and my students I'm held in some good esteem but there are always people, it is quicker to have the written music and many people seek that. They may transcribe something and that's from their ear, it's been a good job, more thorough than sometimes what I do, but then they re-learn it using their eye. And so when I talk about images they might say oh what's — you know but some enjoy my thoughts, my memories, but people want speed now.

MR: Did you have times in academia where it was a bit difficult to justify spending so much time on developing an ear. I guess what I'm trying to say is you have to justify courses to an academic council.

RB: Yes.

MR: And to say we're going to spend a whole semester listening.

RB: Yeah, and you'll perform ten — thank gosh I've had Gunther Schuller to start me off, Hankus and Eden MacAdams, who've really have supported me. These are faculty and through the years I've had some students really very interested, impressed, maybe exalted that they can do this, but it does take time. Big bands expect you to read well and of course they should, and some of my students were from, were orchestra players doing music from the Baroque to the modern. So they may feel some kind of a cult.

MR: I see. I'm going to take you back and challenge your memory I think but the work you did in the 60s with Jeanne Lee and I listened to the "Newest Sounds Around You Never Heard."

RB: Which Aaron produced.

MR: Oh that's terrific. What an important contribution. And imagine my surprise when I saw that you two did "A Hard Day's Night."

RB: Yeah.

MR: So do you recall the accompaniment that you came up with, especially if you were a Beatles fan, was rather jarring and do you recall coming up with that and what Jeanne — did she have trouble singing to it?

RB: Well I'll try to ask her tonight in my dreams. I don't know it just hit [plays piano]. I was hearing Monk at the time and I think Chris Connor covered that piece. That's so long ago, we did it at a house party in Stockholm and it got to be something that we would occasionally do as an encore. Maybe we thought at the beginning we were, I hate to use this word, slumming — we know the Beatles are marvelous, well presented group. But Jeanne and I would dig more of the Silvers and other groups. So but we're talking about now, of the mid-70s, and I could produce a very convincing eight minute story that would be very untrue, very few memories.

MR: Well if you did "A Hard Day's Night" one day for an event and then the next day you did it again, would it be appreciably different?

RB: Well we'd have to ask you if you were in the audience if you could stand my solo Third Stream Noir. I'm not — I do listen to myself subconsciously but again my, I can't really say I have plots for the Beatles pieces. I've also tried "Yesterday" and I like the piece "Julia" very much, which I did when visiting Maryland. But I know Jeanne and a wonderful singers like Dominique Eade, Christine Correa, who've performed with me, Sara Serpa, they don't seem to complain, and I think Houston Person who I adore might have a little bit but I loved playing with Ricky Ford, David "Knife" Fabris, so I don't really hear myself back. Some of my performances aren't recorded or else I need the skills to press these buttons to hear it back.

MR: Well I wonder if you've seen, it was about that time that you were working with Jeanne Lee and a film from 1963 and you two are on stage and you get introduced in French.

RB: Antibes.

MR: Yes.

RB: It was the Antibes Festival and we did "All About Ronnie" for one piece.

MR: Okay. So you came out and you didn't have any music, which is not that surprising, but at some point in the song you are looking at her waiting for her to hit a note, and I've done some accompanying, and so in my head I'm wondering does Ran know what note she's about to sing and is it guiding his chord or whatever, choice, what he's about to play?

RB: Often it does. Often I can predict what she's going to produce, her tone, her beautiful, dark, velvet voice. But there are other times I'm just flabbergasted. I'm thrilled by a note she will come up with. And I think, I don't really scrutinize my — I probably, one part of the sound that I had in my head might come but I would curtail it to Jeanne. And there are things she's done. I'm still horrified, I think one of the best things we did is our first album, "Laura." But there's one time where I play a chord very loudly and I was afraid of interrupting her vocal. I mean I know the instrumentalist has a right occasionally to take over, but I really think it's so important to hear the human voice. But she really can

surprise me, to get back to your — so I'm only able to predict occasionally. And I'm not sure I'm consciously thinking of this. There must be something in me that does.

MR: I think one of her skills must have been the ability to not get thrown off by your accompaniment. I'm not sure that sounds right, except that I've accompanied singers where if I play something that either was a mistake or my try at a nice chord substitution and I get that dirty look from the singer. And boy she was very skilled at hanging on to what she was doing.

RB: And she heard me a lot on solo piano and I've heard her with other groups and of course I could say maybe you're performing with the wrong singer.

MR: Thank you for that. That makes me feel a little better. Let me talk about song titles for a moment. Do you write pieces with a song title in mind? Or do you name them halfway through or perhaps when they're done?

RB: Well rarely do I think of it before. I know I've written two pieces in the last year that I wish musicians would cover, "Memphis" for Martin Luther King, Jean Plumez, and "The Short Life of Barbara Monk." With Barbara Monk I remember getting ready to take off at Logan Airport to get to the funeral and I passed out in Boston and I went home thinking of Barbara and her mother Nellie and the whole family and the cousin Jackie Beneaux, and I wrote for his niece [plays piano]. But in "Memphis" I thought particularly maybe shall I call it "Detroit" and my colleague Hankus Netsky, a wonderful recording artist, said this sounds more southern. And then I kept thinking of the assassination in Memphis. And in my various renditions there's something — we do a melody that I might imagine Al Green doing and then suddenly little things happen like I have a little motif [plays piano] and that comes in very discretely at first and the playing goes on and then it becomes wild as the killer is getting his ammunition all ready with the help of an ally or two, and then, so there are things that are thought through, early pieces like Vanguard are just in space. There's no real plot. But every time I play it there may be often I play it missing Jeanne because she sang it with me so many times.

MR: Oh that's very interesting. Some of these thoughts that I have and these questions, I don't really honestly think they have an answer. Like what does music mean? What can it mean if it's an abstract art form, especially if there's no singing? There's no clear story. So will it affect different people very differently.

RB: I know that I try to have a written program. First it's sort of a nuisance to people to get them to type it up, and secondly some people arriving at a club just a minute before don't read the program notes. Once in a while I have the courage to get up and speak or often I have somebody that will represent me. I don't like to speak much because then I go out of my mood of playing and trying to deal with the audience and when lights go on I get back to the present life. But you're very, very right, like somebody doing a crash-bang on

Abbey and Max doing — I should mention last names, Roach and Lincoln — doing "Freedom Day." And somebody just hearing it instrumentally without the words might think it's, or they may have heard one word, freedom, they may think freedom to get out of school in May. I want summer. I don't want discipline. So rarely do they get it right. But this might hold the music together for me and other people. I know when my "Blue Potato" came out, my third or fourth record, at the same time Charles Haden's "Liberation Orchestra" and a lot of it was instrumental. I haven't heard it for a while. So I think very often it doesn't convey — when I do "Mendacity" — Max Roach's piece — and Abbey mentions voting rights they may have just thought — I don't even know if the people know the background or care and the music meanwhile has to hold up, does it stay together. And there are times I do really, particularly away from the piano, think of the beginning and what I might do as a departure when I go in my world of improvisation, what register of the piano, the role of pedals, and sometimes I follow that and often there's a different plot, a different character that persuades me to go in a different direction.

MR: Wonderful. Let's suppose you wanted to express your feelings about January 6th, 2021.

RB: Horrible date.

MR: Yeah. Would you have something in your mind before you got to the piano?

RB: Yes. It wouldn't be this. It would be more like this [plays piano] and on and on it would go. And it would be very disturbing and I can see people breaking in and here everybody's mentioned the very decent police that tried to protect the people inside the buildings. And one had a heart attack, and innocent people got hurt. So yes, I would, and I think if I played this every day there would be a cluster of notes that would appear. I might revert to [plays piano] my opening of "Memphis" thinking of the crowd and Martin Luther King but it would immediately come back to Washington and it might not be as premeditated, my musical composition ideas of Donald Trump were, I think he orchestrated it, like he felt he was the Tchaikovsky captain of the east coast. But I would have an idea just like when I play "Barbara Monk" [plays piano]. Suddenly I might go into [plays piano] knowing how fond Nica was of Barbara. So a lot is going on there, which is not to say that that's happening to a lot of musicians who come up with wonderful ideas.

MR: I'd like to veer off for a moment, along those lines, do you have a feeling about current events and what it says about our country and human nature?

RB: Yes. It's very sad. I've started a piece called "2020." And the first part is isolation, it's still continuing through '21. I sometimes don't replay them often so there are fragments that remain in my memory, but I know that midway or at the end would be disillusionment and have we lost the old spirit, was the country better, it certainly wasn't

in racism but where there are things still, and now we see the disease, the cancer spreading around the whole world, and diseases that cannot be fixed by vaccination. We seem to have intolerance from history to history to present to future, of all kinds. Very, very tragic. What can the youth think for tomorrow?

MR: Do you have a second ear available to you? The reason I bring this up, I had the distinct pleasure some years ago of interviewing Dave Brubeck in his house, and he was working on a piece, it was the moment where we had sent — the war in Afghanistan had started. And he was writing this piece and it was very dark. And he said that Iola —

RB: Was it recorded?

MR: I don't think so. But he said now Iola said no one's going to want to do this piece, it's too sad. And you know it was an interesting moment. And I wonder if you have people who will comment on your music as it's in progress.

RB: Yes sometimes I don't play it because a lot of social life has been curtailed and Aaron has released a few video performances here that took place a lot during early last winter. I've gotten some general positive feedback but I think with everybody's situation and maybe they're hearing really the very big names in music, sometimes it's ignored. I don't really get a definite feedback. I've also tried to write a piece or two that's happy but that's much harder. But Dave Brubeck, I'd love to hear that. A little side note, my first time I ever got on the airplane Jeanne Lee was with me and in front of me was Iola Brubeck. And she said, "Kids, don't worry, we're not going to crash." I think Jeanne and I were going like that and we asked for extra brandy. And Iola was wonderful.

MR: She was. And she was a big part of his career.

RB: Yeah, really.

MR: What about the mechanical part of writing your music down?

RB: I do very little — I did a piano sonata for my graduation at Bard College and Gunther said, "Good, Ran, join mankind. You really are mediocre sometimes." So, but I just knew compositions that you have the B theme. Then you have improvisation, and then there's a fancy word when you come back and repeat the themes in different keys.

MR: Ah yes, the recapitulation I think.

RB: Yes recapitulation. And I had to say this on an oral test at Bard College but I — maybe, probably as a kid I had dyslexia on reading, and now I have ear dyslexia. If I'm going to learn a language I can read it but I just had my record player on all the time in Springfield, Massachusetts and wherever, and later New York and here. And so I've missed many events of growing up. I just had to hear this record, "Scythian Suite" by Prokofiev, Shostakovich's Tenth Symphony. I remember standing up at the Bushnell Memorial Auditorium in Hartford when one chord was — Shostakovich is sometimes a milder composer but there's a shocking chord in the first movement and I screamed out

loud, and some guy behind me said, "Should I put some restraint on you?" But, and then Monk, how he ended "I Should Care." Chris Connor's version of "Driftwood" which nobody seems to play anymore. Abbey's "Throw It Away," "Down Here Below", Mal Waldron "Straight Ahead."

MR: That's certainly something for those moments. I had one where I was at a Mahavishnu Orchestra concert with John McLaughlin and Billy Cobham did something on the drums that made me like leap out of my seat. And I'm not prone to do that kind of thing.

RB: And Billy of course.

MR: Yes. Recently I had a conversation with a friend that I've had an almost 50-year friendship, a fellow musician, and maybe because we had some of that same brandy that you had on the plane, but we were getting sort of reminiscing about our careers and we got into the what are we leaving behind? Have we made any contributions that will outlive us? And so I guess I'm wondering, have you thought about your legacy? What do you hope will be Ran Blake's lasting contribution?

RB: I love a couple of — more than a couple, I love my music to be performed by others, but I think my legacy is the book. It could be longer, I could revitalize it with experiences. But as it was I had so many people like Jason Rogers helping me and so many others. I think that the ears should be used more. Now this is not my invention, in India, Africa, from grandmother to grandson, this tradition has been around us and it may have been through the beginning of Duke Ellington when starting his band in Washington. But it's not really used well enough and I think many people are trying and there's some wonderful music that will last and have many more implications than my own. But I do feel as an educator I've tried my best to get people to go back to fundamental sound and it's more than just singing back a melody but you hear that, you get a little of the melodic rhythm, you get a sound of orchestra register, the timbre, the sound of a decay. Would that be somebody aging or would it be an inspiration of a beautiful feeling of spring that our young people have only the saddened over the years, and then they have a very early autumn.

MR: You're a poet also, Ran. Thank you for that.

RB: I have a question for you.

MR: Yes, okay.

RB: Did your interviews start or were you already at Hamilton? You've done some intriguing —

MR: I'd been at Hamilton just a couple of years as an adjunct teaching the saxophone, which I still do there. But we can thank an alum named Milt Fillius for this project. It was his idea and his initiative. And I was basically engaged to try to carry out his wishes.

RB: I wish we had brandy right now to toast him and say a prayer.

MR: We would. He changed my life.

RB: Isn't that wonderful.

MR: Yes and it's interesting to know that I think that Milt's musical tastes, he was very passionate about music but if we were, if the three of us were in a room talking about — and Charlie Parker's name came up, he would go [growls] oh, na, na. His tastes were in the swing world but he had, thankfully he sort of let me go with the project before he passed away and so here I am with you.

RB: And thank you Milt though, for making this possible, even though he would feel nauseous if he heard me play.

MR: Well I don't know, that's a strong word.

RB: Yes it is.

MR: But the bit you played, like you reach out to the piano on occasion during this interview and you put your hands down, I'm wondering if you put a chord type to what you're playing. Oh here's a D flat 13 chord. Do you think that way?

RB: No I can't say I never — I mean well even in teaching I think more of triad progressions going to different keys rather than, I love the three years, there are three great years in Stan Kenton's life from '48 to '51 or 2 and then the awful trash that came — so those have skyscraper chords but I just hear things. Would you like me to play a standard or one of my own pieces, or do we have time? We're about to close maybe in five or ten minutes.

MR: Yeah. I would love to hear, actually I'd love to hear something of your own, if you'd like to play, yeah, I would really enjoy that.

[audio interlude]

RB: And of course I don't usually play this so briefly but immediately and of course the lights are on, I'm with Monk Rowe, Aaron's here, my wonderful cat DekTor Dutra! on my right, but that was "Barbara Monk." Sometimes I pop to other Monk songs but this is the memory of Barbara, Toots, Nellie, Thelonious, Nica, Charlie Rouse, so many people that love Monk.

MR: You're very into dynamics and setting up expectations and sometimes giving us what we might expect and then sometimes not. I especially like the part where it sort of eased into that nice waltz.

RB: Yes. I saw her waltzing almost on ice in Central Park and of course as the memories go on I sense I'm there watching her for ten minutes and of course this is exaggeration but I remember a Thanksgiving turkey supper I took her out to because her mother made wonderful organic food, but I don't think meat was encouraged. Monk, it's so great to be with you. I've loved your show for years.

MR: There's a great deal to learn from you and I think — I don't have people talking about some of these things, so this has been very valuable for me.

RB: You came up with some wonderful questions and thoughts.

MR: Thank you. If you were to play something, I'm trying to think of the connection between your composing and your 80-some years of memories. Do you have memories that come to you, I mean I know that you had said something about trying to affect the way you dream.

RB: Yes. And one time there was so much disease, racism, everything going on that I said I want to go into an elegant drawing room and have a Agatha Christie mystery where the murdered person is really a terrible person, so there's no guilt about somebody's death. I've tried that three or four times in the winter and only one time was I successful, but I have a lot of nightmares. I really like to be alone in my room because sometimes it can be noisy with some of my reflections.

MR: Yeah. Well you certainly have made an impact on a lot of people, and I thank you for that. I also am appreciative of how quiet your cat was during the interview.

RB: He usually is more visible and I hope you'll sometime visit Brookline, Massachusetts or the Conservatory in Boston because we're celebrating our fiftieth anniversary next year. So people from the past, people there, and we have a marvelous jazz chairperson, Ken Schaphorst who does beautiful arrangements. And I continue still — I call what I do when I think of models — "recomposing" because I add myself but I still want to allude to, I want to allude to somebody else. You're a great listener, Monk. You have been on all your interviews.

MR: Thank you. I take that as a high compliment. So I'm going to pause our recording here and then we'll have our official good-bye, all right?

RB: Okay.

MR: Thank you Mr. Blake.